EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER I)

RISORGIMENTO & CAVOUR

EXAM QUESTIONS :	2025 Q.4: 'Assess the role of nationalism and realpolitik in the unification of Italy and Germany. How did the leadership of **Cavour and Bismarck** redefine the balance of power?' 2022 Q.4: 'Critically analyze the role of **Count Cavour** in the Unificatiosn of Italy.' 2016 Q.4: 'Compare the roles of **Mazzini, Cavour,** and **Garibaldi** in the Risorgimento.' 2013 Q.7: 'Explain the role of **Garibaldi, Mazzini,** and **Cavour** in the Unification of Italy.'
SYLLABUS :	Paper I; Section 6: Risorgimento and the Union of Italy (1815–1870)
THESIS:	A classic tripartite synthesis: Mazzini provided the moral soul and revolutionary ideology; **Garibaldi** provided the martial sword and popular heroism; **Cavour** provided the diplomatic brain and Realpolitik that actually made unity viable.

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY

1. The Triad of Italian Unity: Giuseppe Mazzini ('The Soul' - Young Italy), Count Camillo Cavour ('The Brain' - Prime Minister of Piedmont-Sardinia), and Giuseppe Garibaldi ('The Sword' - Leader of the Redshirts). King Victor Emmanuel II provided the constitutional symbol.
2. Cavour's Realpolitik realization: 'Italia farà da sé' (Italy will make herself) was a romantic illusion shattered in 1848; Italy could only be unified by securing foreign Great Power alliance against the Austrian Empire (Pact of Plombières with Napoleon III).
3. The Critical Flashpoint (1860): Garibaldi's conquest of Naples threatened to march on Papal Rome, which would trigger French Catholic military intervention. Cavour marched Piedmontese troops south, meeting Garibaldi at Teano, where Garibaldi magnanimously yielded his conquests to Victor Emmanuel II.

1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY

FRAGMENTED ITALY (1815): 'A geographical expression' (Metternich) ➔ Divided into 8 Austrian-dominated states
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  ├── **THE IDEOLOGICAL SPARK (MAZZINI & CARBONARI):** Young Italy (1831) ➔ Republican moral awakening
  │ └── **1848 FAILURE:** 'Italia farà da sé' collapses at Custoza & Novara ➔ Austria reconquers Lombardy
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  ├── **CAVOUR'S DIPLOMATIC REALPOLITIK (PIEDMONT-SARDINIA):**
  │ ├── **Internal Modernization:** Railways, free trade, army reform under Victor Emmanuel II
  │ ├── **Crimean War (1855):**Bought a seat at Congress of Paris (1856) to internationalize the Italian Question
  │ └── **Pact of Plombières (1858)**: Secret military pact with Napoleon III against Austria
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  ├── **MILITARY UNIFICATION (1859–1860):**
  │ ├── **War of 1859 (Magenta & Solferino)** ➔ Liberation of Lombardy; Annexation of Central Duchies
  │ └── **GARIBALDI'S SWORD (1860):** Expedition of the Thousand ➔ Conquest of Sicily & Naples
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  └── **THE TEANO HANDSHAKE & COMPLETION:** Victor Emmanuel declared King (1861) ➔ Venetia (1866) ➔ Rome (1870)

2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES

YEAR	EVENT / ACTION	HISTORICAL & EXAM SIGNIFICANCE
1831	Mazzini Founds 'Young Italy' (Giovine Italia)	Replaces regional Carbonari secrecy with open national republican propaganda across Italian youth.
1848–1849	Failed Revolutions & Abdication of Charles Albert	Piedmontese armies defeated by Austrian Marshal Radetzky; proves Italy cannot liberate herself without Great Power aid.
Nov 1852	Count Cavour Appointed Prime Minister	Embarks on modernization of Piedmont's economy, infrastructure, and military strength.
1855–1856	Piedmont Enters Crimean War & Congress of Paris	Cavour commits 15,000 troops; earns British and French goodwill; puts Italian suffering on European agenda.
July 1858	Pact of Plombières with Napoleon III	France agrees to aid Piedmont against Austria in exchange for Nice and Savoy if Austria fires first.
April 1859	Austro-Sardinian War (Magenta & Solferino)	Austrian forces driven out of Lombardy; armistice of Villafranca cedes Lombardy to Piedmont.
May 1860	Garibaldi's Expedition of the Thousand (I Mille)	Redshirts land in Marsala, overthrow the Bourbon Kingdom of the Two Sicilies in dramatic blitzkrieg.
Oct 1860	Meeting at Teano	Garibaldi hands over southern conquests to King Victor Emmanuel II, avoiding civil war with Piedmont.
March 1861	Proclamation of the Kingdom of Italy	Italian Parliament convenes in Turin; Victor Emmanuel II crowned King of Italy.
1866 & 1870	Acquisition of Venetia and Rome	Italy capitalizes on Bismarck's wars against Austria (1866) and France (1870) to complete territorial unity.

Introduction

In 1815, Prince Metternich famously dismissed Italy as merely a 'geographical expression'—a fragmented peninsula divided into eight reactionary, Austrian-dominated statelets. Yet, within half a century, this fractured territory was transformed into a unified, sovereign national state. **The Italian Risorgimento (resurgence)** represents one of the most remarkable triumphs of nineteenth-century nationalism. Historically, this achievement was not the work of a single political force, but rather the result of a dynamic, often antagonistic synthesis among three distinct personalities: **Giuseppe Mazzini** (the ideological 'Soul'), **Giuseppe Garibaldi** (the martial 'Sword'), and **Count Camillo Cavour** (the diplomatic 'Brain'). While romantic revolutionaries provided the moral **impetus**[1], it was Cavour's masterful application of **Realpolitik**—harnessing Piedmont-Sardinia's institutional power and manipulating Great Power rivalries—that transformed a romantic dream into geopolitical reality.

Mazzini and the Ideological Foundation: The Soul of Risorgimento

The intellectual architecture of Italian nationalism was laid by **Giuseppe Mazzini** through his revolutionary movement, **Young Italy (Giovine Italia)**, founded in 1831. Rejecting the ineffective, aristocratic secrecy of the early **Carbonari**, **Mazzini** democratized the national struggle, infusing it with moral fervor, republican idealism, and divine mission. He championed the concept of **'Italia farà da sé' (Italy will make herself)**, insisting that a spontaneous, popular uprising of the Italian masses would simultaneously overthrow Austrian tyranny and unite the peninsula under a democratic republic. Although Mazzini's romantic insurrections between 1831 and 1848 repeatedly ended in bloody fiascoes, his tireless propaganda succeeded in nationalizing the Italian consciousness, inspiring an entire generation of educated youth to view Italian unity as a sacred duty.

[1] Impetus means the force, energy, or stimulus that makes something happen or move faster.

Cavour's Realpolitik and the Diplomatic Internationalization of Italy

The tragic defeat of Piedmont in the 1848–49 revolutions decisively proved that romantic republicanism could never defeat the professional armies of the Austrian Empire. When Count Camillo di Cavour became Prime Minister of Piedmont-Sardinia in 1852, he replaced Mazzinian idealism with pragmatic, calculated **Realpolitik**. Cavour recognized two inescapable truths: **first**, Piedmont-Sardinia under King Victor Emmanuel II must serve as the constitutional, modernized engine of unification; **second**[2], Austria could only be expelled through the armed intervention of a foreign Great Power. Cavour industrialized Piedmont, expanding railways, modernizing the port of Genoa, and balancing the budget. In 1855, he audaciously entered the **Crimean War**, dispatching 15,000 Piedmontese troops to aid Britain and France. At the subsequent **Congress of Paris (1856)**, Cavour harvested his diplomatic dividend, isolating Austria and capturing the active sympathy of Emperor Napoleon III of France.

The Plombières Pact and the War of 1859

Cavour's supreme diplomatic maneuver culminated in the secret **Pact of Plombières (July 1858)** with Napoleon III. France agreed to join Piedmont in a war against Austria, provided Austria appeared as the aggressor, in exchange for the territorial cession of Nice and Savoy. Cavour brilliantly baited Austria into issuing an ultimatum in April 1859 by staging provocative military maneuvers along the Lombard frontier. In the ensuing **War of 1859**, combined French and Sardinian forces smashed the Austrian army at Magenta and Solferino, liberating Lombardy. Although Napoleon III abruptly signed the separate **Armistice of Villafranca** due to mounting domestic Catholic opposition, Cavour successfully capitalized on popular revolutions across central Italy (Tuscany, Parma, Modena, Romagna), orchestrating plebiscites that annexed these wealthy duchies to Piedmont.

Garibaldi's Sword and the Climax at Teano (1860)

The unification process was brought to a dramatic **crescendo**[3] in May 1860 through the audacious heroism of Giuseppe Garibaldi. Leading his legendary expedition of **one thousand Redshirts (I Mille)**, Garibaldi landed in Sicily and overthrew the corrupt Bourbon dynasty of the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies in a lightning campaign. However, Garibaldi's explosive success created an acute geopolitical emergency: had he marched on Rome as planned, French troops guarding the Pope would have intervened, triggering a catastrophic international war. In a masterstroke of decisive statecraft, Cavour dispatched the royal Piedmontese army south through Papal territories to intercept Garibaldi. At the historic **Meeting of Teano**[4] **(October 26, 1860)**, Garibaldi, placing national unity above personal republican ideology, greeted Victor Emmanuel II as 'King of Italy' and surrendered his conquests, allowing the formal proclamation of the unified **Kingdom of Italy in March 1861**.

Conclusion

The completion of Italian unification—with the acquisition of **Venetia in 1866** via alliance with Prussia, and the annexation of **Rome in 1870** following the collapse of the French Second Empire—confirmed the triumph of Realpolitik over romanticism. As historian Denis Mack Smith observed, Italy was not unified by a spontaneous national uprising, but through the brilliant diplomatic convergence of revolutionary heroism and monarchical statecraft. Mazzini awakened the national conscience, Garibaldi conquered half the peninsula with reckless courage, but it was Cavour's cold, calculated diplomacy that integrated these volatile currents into a permanent nation-state, fundamentally shattering Metternich's Vienna order.

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[2] The Austrian Empire could only be successfully expelled from the Italian peninsula with the military assistance of a foreign Great Power.

[3] Crescendo: the scattered revolutionary efforts suddenly accelerated and peaked.

[4] **The Handover at Teano**

The climax of the crisis was resolved not through bloodshed, but through political compromise at the historic **Meeting of Teano on October 26, 1860**:

- **The Surrender:** Garibaldi placed national unity above his personal republican ideology.
- **The Proclamation:** He greeted Victor Emmanuel II as the "King of Italy" and selflessly surrendered his southern conquests to the crown.

This crucial concession paved the way for the official proclamation of the unified **Kingdom of Italy in March 1861.**

4. QUOTES

HISTORIAN	ANALYTICAL PERSPECTIVE	EXACT QUOTABLE ARGUMENT
Denis Mack Smith	Cavour and Garibaldi 1860	Cavour's genius lay in his capacity to exploit the revolutionary momentum of Garibaldi and the moral idealism of Mazzini while neutralizing their radical republicanism.
A.J.P. Taylor	The Struggle for Mastery in Europe	Cavour was the greatest diplomatic craftsman of the nineteenth century; he alone knew how to make the great powers serve his local ambitions.
Stuart T. Miller	Mastering Modern European History	Without Mazzini there would have been no desire for unity; without Garibaldi there would have been no conquest of the South; without Cavour there would have been no Italian state.
Count Camillo Cavour	Speech to Parliament (1860)	If we did for ourselves what we did for our country, what scoundrels we would be!
Giuseppe Garibaldi	Proclamation to the Redshirts (1860)	Italy and Victor Emmanuel! Let all discord vanish, and let our sacred soil be cleansed of foreign tyrants.